

47

Deborah

The prophetess and judge who called Israel to battle and sang of the LORD's victory.

Deborah is the only judge in the book of Judges who is also called a prophet, and the only woman among them. She held court under a palm tree in the hill country of Ephraim, and the people came to her to settle their disputes. For twenty years Jabin king of Canaan had crushed Israel with nine hundred iron chariots. God gave Deborah a message for Barak: gather an army at Mount Tabor, and the LORD would deliver Sisera, Jabin's general, into his hand. Barak would not go without her, so she went. God routed the chariots at the river Kishon, and Deborah and Barak sang one of the oldest songs in the Bible. The land had rest forty years.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Devorah</i> , "bee"
Family	Wife of Lapidoth (Judges 4:4)
Roles	Prophetess, judge, singer; "a mother in Israel" (Judges 5:7)
When	After Ehud and Shamgar. Any BC date is rough
Key places	The palm tree of Deborah between Ramah and Bethel; Mount Tabor; the river Kishon
Key people	Barak, Jael, Sisera, Jabin king of Canaan
Main passages	Judges 4–5
New Testament	Not named

"The inhabitants of the villages ceased, they ceased in Israel, until that I Deborah arose, that I arose a mother in Israel."

Judges 5:7, KJV

The life of Deborah

Judges gives no calendar dates; on the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC. Any date for Deborah is rough.

Twenty years	●	Jabin oppresses Israel Israel does evil again. Jabin king of Canaan and his captain Sisera oppress Israel with nine hundred chariots of iron. <i>Judges 4:1–3</i>
Under the palm tree	●	Judges Israel Deborah, a prophetess, sits under a palm tree in mount Ephraim, and the people come to her for judgment. <i>Judges 4:4–5</i>
A word from God	●	Summons Barak She calls Barak and gives God's command: take ten thousand men to Mount Tabor, and Sisera will be given into his hand. <i>Judges 4:6–7</i>
At Kedesh	●	Goes with Barak Barak will not go unless she goes too. She agrees, but warns that the honour will go to a woman. <i>Judges 4:8–10</i>
At Mount Tabor	●	Gives the signal Sisera gathers his chariots by the Kishon. Deborah tells Barak, "Up; for this is the day." <i>Judges 4:12–14</i>
By the Kishon	●	The LORD routs Sisera The LORD throws Sisera's army into confusion. Sisera flees on foot and is killed by Jael in her tent. <i>Judges 4:15–22</i>
That day	●	Sings the song Deborah and Barak sing of God's victory, praising the willing and blessing Jael. <i>Judges 5:1–31</i>
Forty years	●	The land rests Jabin is destroyed, and the land has rest forty years. <i>Judges 4:23–24; 5:31</i>

Key activities

Judges 4 tells the battle as a story, Judges 5 as a poem. The poem adds rain and a river that swept the enemy away; many readers think a storm bogged down the chariots (Judges 5:4, 20–21).

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- I Judged the people.** She settled Israel's disputes under the palm tree that bore her name. *Judges 4:4–5*

 - 2 Spoke for God.** As a prophetess she gave Barak God's command and promise. *Judges 4:6–7*

 - 3 Went with Barak.** She replied, "I will surely go with thee." *Judges 4:8–9*

 - 4 Named the day.** She told Barak, "is not the LORD gone out before thee?" *Judges 4:14*

 - 5 Saw God fight.** The LORD "discomfited Sisera, and all his chariots." *Judges 4:15*

 - 6 Sang praise first to God.** Her song begins, "Praise ye the LORD for the avenging of Israel." *Judges 5:1–5*

 - 7 Remembered hard times.** She recalled empty highways and villages, until she "arose a mother in Israel." *Judges 5:6–8*

 - 8 Honoured the willing.** She praised the leaders and people who "offered themselves willingly." *Judges 5:2, 9, 14–15, 18*

 - 9 Rebuked the absent.** Reuben, Gilead, Dan and Asher stayed home, and Meroz was cursed for not coming "to the help of the LORD." *Judges 5:15–17, 23*

 - 10 Blessed Jael.** She sang, "Blessed above women shall Jael the wife of Heber the Kenite be." *Judges 5:24–27*

 - 11 Imagined the enemy's mother.** The song ends with Sisera's mother at the window, waiting for a son who will not come home. *Judges 5:28–30*

 - 12 Closed with a prayer.** "So let all thine enemies perish, O LORD." *Judges 5:31*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Deborah.

Old Testament

Judges 4:1–24	The battle against Sisera, told as a story
Judges 5:1–31	Her song, counted by many among the oldest poems
Psalm 83:9–10	"As to Sisera, as to Jabin, at the brook of Kison"
Joshua 11:1–11	An earlier Jabin of Hazor; perhaps a royal title (debated)
Genesis 35:8	A different Deborah, Rebekah's nurse
Echo: Exodus 15:20–21; 2 Kings 22:14	Miriam and Huldah, other prophetesses
Echo: 1 Samuel 2:1–10	Hannah's song of reversed fortunes

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32	Deborah is not named, but Barak is
Echo: Luke 2:36–38; Acts 21:9	Anna and Philip's daughters prophesied
Echo: Luke 1:46–55	Mary's song: God "hath put down the mighty"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What roles did Deborah fill for Israel (Judges 4:4–6; 5:7)?
2. *Understand:* Her song praises God first and people second. Why is that order important?
3. *Apply:* Deborah honoured those who "offered themselves willingly." Where could you volunteer this month?
4. *Apply:* Reuben had "great searchings of heart" but stayed home (Judges 5:16). What good intention do you need to turn into action?